China first in order to determine how we will play the triangular relationship in South Asia."[236]

The president went even further, asking McNamara, "Is it worth normalizing our relations?"[237] This question partly reflected India's now limited utility for American plans in Asia. At a time when shared bilateral interests seemed to be lacking, the US ambassador was left emphasizing "shared values" as the "bedrock." The US went from having a specific interest in India to what Keating called a "general interest" in the country.[238]

However, India could still play spoiler—something the US needed to guard against. In early February, Kissinger met with the Indian ambassador, primarily "to keep India quiet while we were in China." He suggested to Jha that India and the US had an opportunity to make a new start and to develop a relationship whereby "India would take the United States less for granted; the United States could give up its sentimentalization of India."[239] Jha, however, noted to Sisco that the Nixon administration came closer to vilifying than sentimentalizing India. He pointed to Nixon's foreign policy report that year as an example, noting that it represented the first instance of "consistent, sustained and sharp criticism of India" by an American president.[240]

Nixon's China policy also affected US policy related to India's neighbors in a manner that rubbed India the wrong way. The White House delayed any recognition of Bangladesh, a key priority for India. In the long term, Rogers pointed out to Nixon that US and Indian interests vis-à-vis Bangladesh would converge, while those of China and the US would diverge. China would seek to encourage a radical Bangladesh that could be used as a base to destabilize India, which Beijing saw "as a long range strategic and political opponent."[241] In the short term, however, Sisco stated, "We need a better feel as to how the Chinese will play it." Kissinger agreed, noting, "I want to be sure that a move toward recognition doesn't jeopardize a larger objective with China."[242] The administration even deferred decisions regarding participation in reconstruction efforts in Bangladesh until after the president's China trip.[243]

The White House also continued to support Pakistan in order to show China that the US was a credible partner. In the lead-up to the China trip, Kissinger told Nixon that it was critical for Washington to show Beijing that it was "reliable enough to deliver" on its commitments or else their